WEEK 5 · LECTURE L1 OF 3 · UNIT II

Talent Acquisition and Digital Onboarding

From signal to belonging: how firms select, and how a new hire becomes an insider.

Part 1 Cold calls on your pod's Round 2 stack

Part 2 Talent acquisition: signals, validity, fit and fairness

Part 3 Onboarding: socialization, India Stack, frontline versus corporate

Read Scully-Russ and Torraco (2020), pp. 83 to 84

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PART 1 · COLD CALLS

Three questions on your pod's Round 2 stack

1 · The record

Which system did your stack name as the single record, and what happened to the other one?

2 · The first hire

Walk us through day one for a new store associate in your design. What does she touch first?

3 · The reach

Which of your modules works on a smartphone, in a regional language?

WHY HERE

Onboarding is where your architecture first meets a real person. Today tests the stack you built.

SOCRATIC OPENER · GL-1001

Lakshmi Naidu, Store Associate, Warangal (Tier 3). Smartphone only, prefers Telugu, 42 months at GreenLeaf. Her one learning record: POSH Compliance, self paced, In-progress, assessment 32 percent.

Was she ever recruited, onboarded and trained, or only processed?

Source: GreenLeaf workbook, Employee_Master and LMS_Learning, row GL-1001

PART A · 0:00 TO 0:35

Talent acquisition: signals, fit and fairness

What does an applicant tracking system read, and what does it miss?

Why do screening models drift toward the past?

How do candidates judge a digital process?

PART A · FIRST, WHAT IS TALENT?

Talent is a product of three Cs, not a sum

Competence

Can do

The knowledge, skills and values the job needs now and in future.

×

Commitment

Will do

The effort and energy a person chooses to give the organization.

×

Contribution

Wants to do

Finding meaning and purpose in the work, so effort lasts.

If any one C is zero, talent is zero. For GL-1001: which C did a 32 percent course score actually measure?

Source: Ulrich, D. and Smallwood, N. (2012). What is talent? *Leader to Leader*, 2012(63), 55 to 61.

PART A · THEORY 1

Hiring is a two way signaling problem

The employer reads the candidate

Spence (1973): when quality is hidden, employers rely on costly signals such as degrees and experience.

An ATS turns signals into keywords and cut offs, so it reads only what was written in its vocabulary.

The candidate reads the employer

Rynes, Bretz and Gerhart (1991): applicants treat delays, tone and process quality as signals of how the firm treats people.

A silent auto rejection is also a signal.

Design question: what does our ATS signal to a Tier 3 walk in applicant, and what can it not read about her?

PART A · THEORY 1b

A screen is only as useful as its validity

Taylor and Russell (1939)

A selection tool adds value through three things together:

validity (does the score predict performance?), the **selection ratio** and the **base rate** of good performers.

Meta analytic evidence

Schmidt and Hunter (1998); revised by Sackett et al. (2022).

Structured interviews rank among the most valid methods; unstructured ones rank lower.

Keyword screens are rarely validated at all.

Rigor test for any ATS: what is its validity against later job performance, and who measured it?

PART A · THEORY 2

The ASA cycle explains why screening models copy the past

Attraction
Similar people apply

→

Selection
Firm picks people like current staff

→

Attrition
Those who do not fit leave

→

Sameness
The workforce narrows

Schneider (1987)

“The people make the place”: attraction, selection and attrition together make an organization more alike over time.

Kristof (1996)

Person organization fit (values) differs from person job fit (skills). A model trained on past hires learns both, mixed.

PART A · THEORY 2b

Five routes by which a hiring model produces disparate impact

Route (Barocas and Selbst, 2016)	How it enters a GreenLeaf screen
1. Target variable	“Good hire” defined as long tenure, which favors groups that faced fewer breaks
2. Labeled examples	Past offers, already skewed, used as the training answer key
3. Feature selection	Fields chosen that exist for some applicants and not others
4. Proxies	Career gap or college stands in for gender or class
5. Masking	A biased choice hidden inside a neutral looking model

Barocas, S. and Selbst, A. D. (2016). Big data's disparate impact. California Law Review, 104(3), 671 to 732.

PART A · THEORY 3

Candidates judge the process, not only the result

Gilliland’s procedural rule (1993)	What a typical ATS does
Job relatedness	Does a keyword match track the job?
Opportunity to perform	Rejected before any human contact
Consistency	Same rule for all: a real strength
Feedback	Silent rejection, no reason given
Two way communication	A chatbot, or nothing

Gilliland, S. W. (1993). The perceived fairness of selection systems. Academy of Management Review, 18(4).

REVISIT · ROUND 4

The algorithmic screen fails the four fifths test

0.60

Algorithm used (77 requisitions)
Female selection 8.32% ÷ male 13.88%

0.98

No algorithm (63 requisitions)
Female selection 13.04% ÷ male 13.32%

Threshold 0.80. Adverse impact is judged on outcomes; intent does not matter. Which theory from the last two slides explains how the gap arose?

Source: Recruitment_ATS. Selection rate = Offers ÷ Applications for each gender, totals pooled by Algorithm_Used.

PART B · 0:35 TO 1:15

Onboarding is socialization, not paperwork

Which design choices does every onboarding make?

What should onboarding actually produce in a newcomer?

Where does India Stack help, and where does it stop?

PART B · THEORY 4

Six choices every onboarding design makes

Institutionalized	Individualized
Collective	Individual
Formal	Informal
Sequential	Random
Fixed	Variable
Serial	Disjunctive
Investiture	Divestiture

What Jones (1986) found

Institutionalized tactics: less role ambiguity, more commitment, a custodial role.

Individualized tactics: more role innovation.

Van Maanen and Schein (1979), Toward a theory of organizational socialization; Jones (1986), Academy of Management Journal.

PART B · THEORY 5

What onboarding must produce: three adjustment states

Inputs

Socialization tactics; the newcomer's own information seeking

→

Adjustment

Role clarity
Self efficacy
Social acceptance

→

Outcomes

Performance, satisfaction, commitment, intention to stay

Measure the middle box. Completion of onboarding tasks is an input, not an outcome.

Bauer, Bodner, Erdogan, Truxillo and Tucker (2007), meta analysis, Journal of Applied Psychology, 92(3).

PART B · THEORY 5b

Newcomers reduce uncertainty by seeking information

Uncertainty reduction

Berger and Calabrese (1975): people in new relationships act to make others predictable.

Newcomers do the same with the organization.

Seeking tactics

Miller and Jablin (1991): overt questions, indirect questions, third parties, testing limits, observing, surveillance.

A chatbot serves only the first.

What they seek

Morrison (1993): technical, referent (role), normative, performance feedback, social.

Normative and social answers come from people.

Prediction: a digital first onboarding answers technical questions well and leaves normative and social uncertainty unresolved.

PART B · THEORY 5c

Onboarding writes the psychological contract

Rousseau (1989; 1995)

Beliefs about mutual promises, held by the employee.

Transactional: pay for work, short term.

Relational: loyalty, growth, long term.

Early breach

Robinson and Rousseau (1994): a majority of new graduates reported a broken promise within two years.

Breach predicted lower trust and higher exit.

Realistic previews

Wanous: met expectations. Premack and Wanous (1985) meta analysis: previews lower inflated expectations; effect on retention is small but reliable.

Design rule: every promise a recruiting app or welcome video makes is a term of the contract the first month must honor.

PART B · THEORY 6

Bauer’s Four Cs: most firms stop at the first

Compliance

Rules, forms, policy sign offs

Clarification

Role and expectations

Culture

Norms, written and unwritten

Connection

Relationships and networks

Passive onboarding

Compliance and some Clarification

Proactive onboarding

All four, planned on purpose

Bauer, T. N. (2010). Onboarding new employees: Maximizing success. SHRM Foundation.

PART B · SYNTHESIS

Three onboarding frameworks, three units of analysis

Framework	What it describes	What it misses
Van Maanen and Schein (1979)	How the organization structures entry (tactics)	The newcomer's own seeking
Bauer (2010), Four Cs	What content onboarding covers	How content is delivered
Klein and Polin (2012): inform, welcome, guide	Concrete practices firms use	Outcomes in the newcomer
Bauer et al. (2007)	Adjustment states and outcomes	Specific practices to use

Rigor rule: use a process framework to design, and an outcome model to evaluate. Mixing them up is the commonest error.

PART B · APPLICATION

India Stack: the onboarding rail for a frontline hire

Aadhaar eKYC
Identity verified in minutes

→

DigiLocker
Verified documents, no photocopies

→

eSign
Offer and policies signed on a phone

→

Bank check
Account confirmed for first salary

Every step pulls personal data. Name its purpose and collect only what is needed (DPDP Act 2023).

The rail completes Compliance. It does nothing for Culture or Connection.

L1 · DIGITAL ONBOARDING

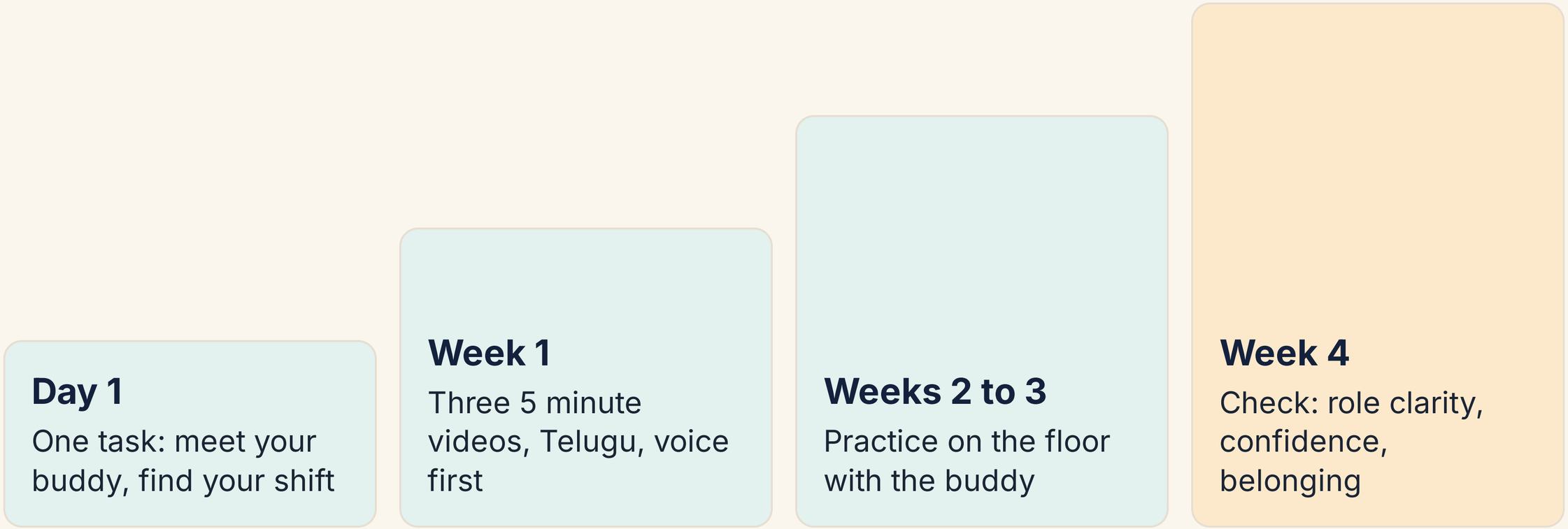
Frontline and corporate onboarding are different journeys

	Corporate new hire	Frontline new hire (like GL-1001)
Device	Laptop issued on day one	Own smartphone; often shared data
Language	English portal works	Needs Telugu, Hindi or another regional language
Documents	Email upload and e-sign	DigiLocker, Aadhaar eKYC and e-sign from the phone
First week	Induction sessions and a manager meeting	On the shop floor in shifts, with a buddy
Success measure	Time to productivity	Still here at 90 days

DESIGN RULE Build the frontline journey first. The corporate journey is the easier special case.

PART B · THEORY 7

Cognitive load: build the first month as a staircase



Sweller (1988), Cognitive load during problem solving, Cognitive Science. Example journey for GL-1001, for discussion.

Going deeper: the theory underneath onboarding

The next slides set out Cable, Gino and Staats on personal identity, and Bandura on self-efficacy: what each claims, how it works, where it breaks, and what it means at GreenLeaf.

THEORY IN DEPTH · CABLE, GINO AND STAATS (2013)

Let newcomers bring themselves to work

THE CORE IDEA

A field experiment at Wipro's call centers in India compared onboarding that stressed the firm's identity with one that stressed the newcomer's own strengths.

HOW IT WORKS

Newcomers asked to share what they do best showed higher retention and customer satisfaction months later.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

One firm and one job type; results may differ elsewhere.

AT GREENLEAF

Lakshmi's first-week flow could ask what she is good at, in Telugu, on her phone. It costs almost nothing.

THEORY IN DEPTH · BANDURA (1977)

Belief in your ability predicts whether you try

THE CORE IDEA

Self-efficacy is confidence that you can perform a specific task.

HOW IT WORKS

Four sources: mastery experiences, watching peers succeed, encouragement, and how your body feels under stress.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Efficacy is task-specific; confidence in one app does not transfer automatically.

AT GREENLEAF

A first ESS task that is easy to complete, shown by a peer from the same store, builds efficacy faster than a manual.

THE HINGE OF THE SESSION

A document checklist completes onboarding for the HRIS. Only connection completes it for the person.